Finally, in November 1915, he committed to print an article giving the complete solution: a new theory of gravity, which he called ‘The General Theory of Relativity’, his masterpiece and the ‘most beautiful of theories’, according to the great Russian physicist Lev Landau.

There are absolute masterpieces which move us intensely: Mozart’s *Requiem*; Homer’s *Odyssey*; the Sistine Chapel; *King Lear*. To fully appreciate their brilliance may require a long apprenticeship, but the reward is sheer beauty – and not only this, but the opening of our eyes to a new perspective upon the world. Einstein’s jewel, the general theory of relativity, is a masterpiece of this order.

I remember the excitement I felt when I began to understand something about it. It was summer. I was on a beach at Condofuri in Calabria, immersed in the sunshine of the Hellenic Mediterranean, and in the last year of my university studies. Undistracted by schooling, one studies best during vacations. I was studying with the help of a book that had been gnawed at the edges by mice, because at night I’d used it to block the holes of these poor creatures in the rather dilapidated, hippy-ish house on an Umbrian hillside where I used to take refuge from the tedium of university classes in Bologna. Every so often I would raise my eyes from the book and look at the glittering sea: it seemed to me that I was actually seeing the curvature of space and time imagined by Einstein. As if by magic: as if a friend was whispering into my ear an extraordinary hidden truth, suddenly raising the veil of reality to disclose a simpler, deeper order. Ever since we discovered that the Earth is round and turns like a mad spinning-top we have understood that reality is not as it appears to us: every time we glimpse a new aspect of it, it is a deeply emotional experience. Another veil has fallen.

But amongst the numerous leaps forward in our understanding that have succeeded each other over the course of history, Einstein’s is perhaps unequalled. Why?

In the first place because, once you understand how it works, the theory has a breathtaking simplicity. I’ll summarize the idea.

Newton had tried to explain the reason why things fall and the planets turn. He had imagined the existence of a ‘force’ which draws all material bodies towards one another, and called it ‘the force of gravity’. How this force was exerted between things distant from each other, without there being anything between them, was unknown – and the great father of modern science was cautious of offering a hypothesis. Newton had also imagined that bodies